Countdown to war, April 1966–7

Key dates

Egypt signed a defence agreement with Syria: 1966

Air fight between Israeli and Syrian planes: 7 April 1967

In February 1966 a new, radical and aggressive government came to power in Syria. It demanded 'revolutionary struggle' against Israel and called for the 'liberation of Palestine'. The Syrians now stepped up their support for the PLO guerrillas and accused the Egyptian government of not supporting them. Nasser was stung, but he did not want war: he knew that the Arab states were not ready and that Israel had stronger military forces than all the neighbouring Arab states combined. Besides, many of his best troops were at war in Yemen (see page 71). Yet he wanted to remain the leader of the Arab world, the champion of Arab nationalism. So, in November 1966, he signed a defence agreement with the Syrian government whereby, if one state was attacked, the other would come to its defence. Nasser hoped the pact would restrain the hotheads in the Syrian government but all it did was encourage them.

Tension was high not only in Syria for a week after the Egyptian–Syrian pact was signed, a mine exploded on the Israel–Jordan frontier, killing three Israeli soldiers. The Israelis retaliated with a massive attack on the Jordanian village of Samu from which they believed the attackers had come. Fifteen Jordanian troops and three civilians were killed and over 100 houses destroyed. In early 1967 there were many more raids and reprisals across the borders. Tension was particularly high on the Israeli–Syrian border: several of Israel's military leaders were keen to provoke clashes with Syria so that they could retaliate forcefully and teach the Syrians a lesson. One particular incident illustrates this.

On 7 April 1967 an Israeli tractor was ploughing land in the demilitarised zone. The Syrians opened fire and the Israelis fired back. The Syrians then started shelling other Israeli settlements in the area. Israeli tanks went into action but could not reach all the positions from which the Syrians had been firing. So Israeli planes were called up. These were then intercepted by Syrian fighter planes and, in the air fight which ensued, six Syrian planes were shot down, two of them over the Syrian capital. The Israeli planes roared low over Damascus, further humiliating the Syrians. Some historians believe that this incident started the countdown to the Six-Day War in June 1967. Many years later, the Israeli leader, Moshe Dayan, explained in an interview that Israel provoked 'at least 80 per cent' of the clashes on the border.

The crisis of May 1967

Key question

Who was to blame for the outbreak of war in June 1967?

By May 1967 Israel and its Arab enemies were sliding into a crisis that neither side could control. Israel issued several threats to act against Syria unless it stopped supporting Palestinian attacks on Israel. On 12 May an Israeli general threatened to occupy the Syrian capital, Damascus, and overthrow the Syrian government. He was severely criticised by the Israeli government but his words were widely interpreted by the Arabs as a sign that Israel intended to attack Syria.